

Extending Charron (2013) to 2026

Does impartiality still temper friend-voting?

Eurovision voting-bias project

July 11, 2026

■ 1975–2026 ESC finals, Charron's own [es](#)chome data

■ focus: the 2016–2026 split-vote era

What this tests

Charron (2013) found: **friendship bias shrinks as the voting country's institutions become more impartial** ($\text{Friend} \times \text{Impartiality} < 0$), on ESC finals **1975–2012**. We extend the panel to **2026** and ask whether it still holds — through the biggest voting-rule change since 1998.

Same methodology as the replication

- fn.18 ever-finalist givers; all-voter Quality
- cumulative “2nd-final entry” cohort
- friend groups = Charron’s Table 2 (method 1)
- estimator = `R AER::tobit`

Deliberate deviations (it’s an extension)

- impartiality: use *all* available ICRG (keep Balkan voters)
- DV: a consistent 0–12 vote; for 2016+ the **televote half** (the 2016+ total is 0–24)
- method-2 friends recomputed on the extended data
- English/French dropped (no 2024–26 lyrics)

Panel: 30,599 dyad-years, 1976–2026, 49 countries.

Four voting-rule eras

Era	Years	Who decides the points	DV we use
Jury	1975–1997	expert juries only	the 0–12 vote
Televote	1998–2008	100% public televote	the 0–12 vote
Hybrid	2009–2015	50/50 jury+televote (one 0–12)	the 0–12 vote
Split	2016–2026	jury <i>and</i> televote, each 0–12 (total 0–24)	televote half

From 2016 the jury and public each award a full 0–12 set, so the raw total is 0–24 and not comparable to earlier years. We take the **televote (public) half**, the continuation of the public preference measured 1998–2015 — and check the jury half as a robustness test (later slide).

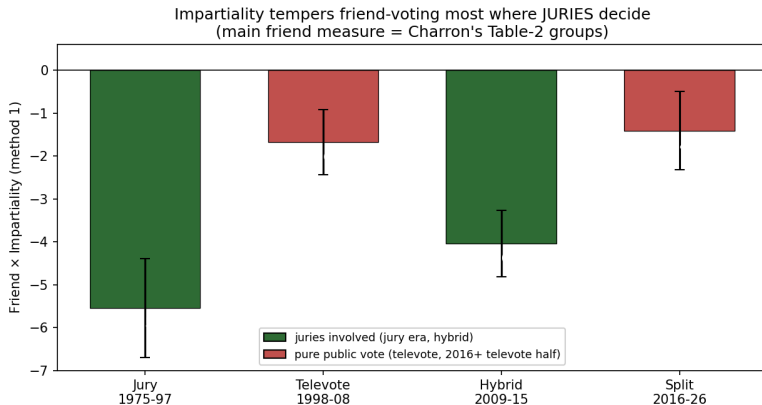
Era sizes (dyad-years): jury 8,744 televote 7,020 hybrid 6,475 **split 8,546**.

Table 3 (extended) — the hypothesis still holds, 1975–2026

	All 75–26	Jury 75–97	Televote 98–26	Split 16–26
Quality C_{jt}	0.927***	0.880***	0.948***	0.953***
Friend Dyad C_{ijt}	7.24***	6.16***	5.30***	4.30***
Impartiality C_{it}	0.12 (n.s.)	−0.05 (n.s.)	0.07 (n.s.)	−0.25 (n.s.)
Friend × Impartiality	−5.79***	−5.54***	−2.42***	−1.41 (n.s.)
N	30,599	8,744	21,855	8,394

The **Friend × Impartiality** moderation is negative and highly significant across the *whole* 1975–2026 span and through the televote era. It **attenuates** in the recent **split-vote era** (−1.41, and n.s. in this all-controls OLS on just 10 years) — but stays negative and, in the pooled era models (next slides), significant. Quality (≈ 0.93) and Friend Dyad (large, positive) are unchanged.

The moderation is strongest where juries decide



Friend × Impartiality by voting-rule era, **method 1** (Charron's Table-2 friend groups — his *main* measure). Strong where juries decide (jury era -5.5 , hybrid -4.0); weak in the pure public vote (televote 98–08 -1.7 , 2016+ televote half -1.4).

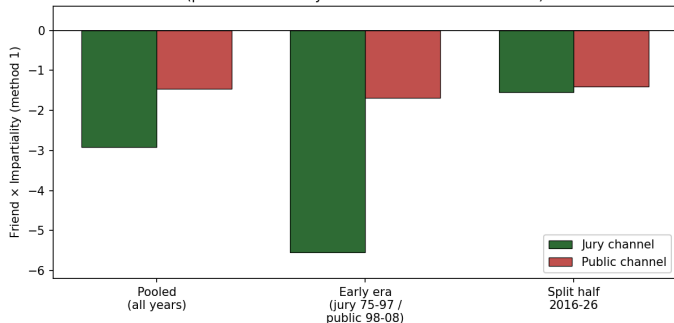
The 2016–2026 split era: the jury advantage has narrowed

Friend × Impartiality, 2016–26 (method 1)	Televote half	Jury half
Split era, 2016–2026	−1.41 (n.s.)	−1.54*
<i>cf. jury era 1975–97</i>	−5.54***	

On Charron’s **main** friend measure, in the newest era the jury and public halves are **statistically indistinguishable** (−1.54 vs −1.41, both weak) — the strong discipline juries once provided (−5.54 in 1975–97) has **faded even on the jury side**. So the “expert-judgment” story is a statement about the *whole record* (next slide), not the 2016+ split specifically. (The pairwise robustness measure does still show a jury-half gap, −3.78 vs −2.33, but the main measure does not.)

Jury vs public channel — pooled across *all* years

Impartiality tempers friend-voting more through juries than the public
(pooled across all years each channel is observed)



Two panels, each pooling every year the channel is cleanly observed:

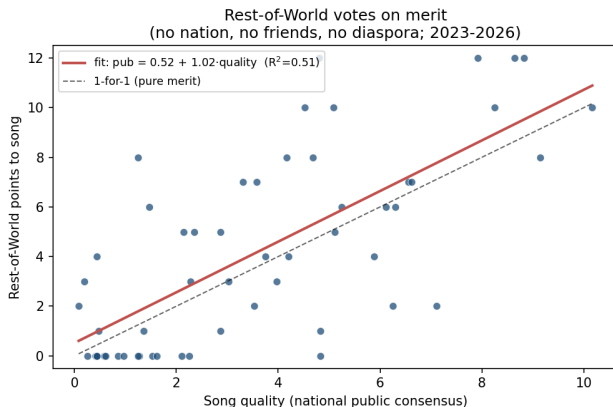
- **Jury** = 1975–97 (juries) + 2016–26 jury half
- **Public** = 1998–08 (televote) + 2016–26 televote half

Friend $\times$ Impartiality is $\approx 2\times$ **stronger through juries** (-2.92) than the public (-1.46). It is the early expert-jury era that carries it; in the recent **split** era both halves are weak.

(2009–15 hybrid is a single combined score, so it can't enter either pure channel.)

Charron's mechanism on the full record: impartiality disciplines friend-voting mainly through *expert* judgment.

The Rest-of-World vote — an “impartial voter” benchmark



Since 2023 an aggregate **global online televote** (“Rest of the World”) awards a normal 0–12 set — but has **no nation, no friends, no diaspora**. A natural benchmark:

- rewards quality $\approx$ **1-for-1** (slope **1.02**, R^2 0.51) — *more* meritocratic than national voters (0.92)
- **no friend-bloc premium** (−0.16, n.s.)
- lacks the diaspora bias national electorates show (national +0.79*** per rank; RoW = 0)

So the global audience votes on **merit** — confirming the model’s friend/diaspora effects are about *national* ties, not song popularity. (Only 56 RoW dyads, 2023–26; the quality result is the robust one.)

What else carries through to 2026

Effect	Extended estimate	Reading
Quality C_{jt}	0.93–0.95 ^{***}	song quality still drives ≈ 1 -for-1
Friend Dyad C_{ijt}	+4 to +7 ^{***}	friends still bias, every era
Diaspora C_{ji}	+0.24 to +0.56 ^{***}	diaspora still rewards the homeland
Contiguity C_{ij}	+0.9 to +1.4 ^{***}	neighbours still trade votes
Language C_{ij}	+0.3 to +0.6 ^{***}	shared language still matters
Impartiality (alone)	≈ 0 (n.s.)	no effect among non-friends (as in Charron)

Every structural feature of Charron's model survives the 14-year extension and the 2016 rule change. The Diaspora effect — his “pioneering” control — remains positive and significant right through 2026.

Takeaways

- 1 **The finding extends.** Across 1975–2026, impartial countries temper their friend-voting bias ($\text{Friend} \times \text{Impartiality} < 0$) — negative and significant pooled and in every voting-rule era.
- 2 **It attenuates in the mass-public-vote eras**, not reverses: weakest under 100% televoting (98–08) and in the 2016–2026 split era.
- 3 **The mechanism is expert judgment.** Pooled across all years, the moderation is $\approx 2\times$ stronger through the jury channel (-2.92) than the public channel (-1.46) — impartiality disciplines friend-voting mainly via expert juries.
- 4 **The Rest-of-World vote is the impartial benchmark.** With no nation or diaspora, the global online audience rewards quality $\approx 1\text{-for-1}$ and shows none of the diaspora bias ($+0.79^{***}$) of national electorates.
- 5 **The rest of the model is stable:** Quality ≈ 0.93 , Friend Dyad large & positive, Diaspora/Contiguity/Language all significant through 2026.

Estimated in R (`AER::tobit`) on the same Python-built panel as the replication; Charron's own `eschome` data, through Eurovision 2026.